

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 5
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Kin-dom Vision
5 July 2026



"Dream Under Construction" by Antonio Masi

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Hymn Improvisation

Meditation on LIFT EVERY VOICE AND SING (Johnson/Johnson, arr. C. Bull)

Theme from *Once Upon A Time In America* (Ennio Morricone, adapted by C. Bull)

Meditations on hymns from the Dakota Odowan

LAC QUI PARLE (Many and Great)

LA FRAMBOISE

RENVILLE

Little Great Prelude (Saginaw Rozzo) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

A Litany of Hope

Esme & Lulu Gregoropoulos

In a time when the forces of division abound,
we have dared to come together on this day.

We come together because our love for God inspires it;
our commitment to humanity insists upon it;
and what we can learn from each other requires it.

In spite of our differences,
we share many commonalities from teachings
across our faith and cultural traditions:

A conviction in the fundamental unity of the human family
and the equality and dignity of all human beings.

A realization that might is not right;
that human power is not self-sufficient or absolute.

A belief that love, compassion, selflessness,
and the force of inner truthfulness and spirit
have ultimately greater power
than hate, enmity, and self-interest.

A sense of obligation to stand with the poor,
the hungry, and the oppressed, and to serve

the cause of justice.

A profound hope that good will finally prevail.

*Today, we affirm our commitment to journey together
as a unified force and as a symbol of what life can be,
when we live together in the diversity
the Creator dreams for all creation.*

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Lift Every Voice And Sing

ANTHEM

Lift every voice and sing 'till earth and heaven ring,
Ring with the harmonies of Liberty.
Let our rejoicing rise high as the list'ning skies,
Let it resound loud as the rolling sea.
Sing a song full of faith that the dark past has taught us.
Sing a song full of the hope that the present has brought us.
Facing the rising sun of our new day begun,
Let us march on till victory is won.

Stony the road we trod, bitter the chast'ning rod,
Felt in the day that hope unborn had died.
Yet with a steady beat have not our weary feet
Come to the place on which our people sighed:
We have come over a way that with tears has been watered.
We have come, treading our path through the blood of the slaughtered.
Out from the gloomy past, till now we stand at last
Where the white gleam of our bright star is cast.

God of our weary years, God of our silent tears,
Thou who has brought us thus far on the way;
Thou who has by thy might led us into the light
Keep us forever in the path, we pray.
Lest our feet stray from the places, our God, where we met thee,
Lest our hearts, drunk with the wine of the world, we forget thee.
Shadowed beneath thy hand, may we forever stand,
True to our God, true to our native land.

-James Weldon and Rosemond Johnson

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Eternal God, today we remember those who have brought us to this place,
who have labored with You
who have labored for us
to make a way out of no way
dreaming dreams and visioning visions
both ancient and new.

We give thanks for that great cloud of witnesses
those who whisper their wisdom in stories, songs, and poems
those who gave birth to movements
and moments
of liberation
of healing
of justice
of love.

On this day, may we remember and honor the legacies of resistance
to evil, injustice, and oppression
that have empowered our being
and invited our becoming.
[adapt/enfleshed]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

“This Hill” (excerpt)
Laude

ESME GREGOROPOULOS

*“This hill, though high, I covet to ascend. The difficulty will me not offend. For I perceive the way of life lies here.
Come pluck up, heart, let’s neither faint nor fear.” ~John Bunyan*

***The Lord’s Prayer**

Shalonda Martin

*Creator of us all,
who dwells within and beyond,
Sacred is your name.
May your holy vision for collective flourishing
come to fruition among us.
May your dreams of justice, love, compassion, and
connection be enfleshed on earth.
Provide us today with what we need to be nourished
in body, soul, and heart.
Forgive us for the harm we cause as we seek to
forgive those who have harmed us.
Lead us away from everything that destroys and
liberate us from the hands of evil.
For you are the ultimate source of hope.
Your power-with exceeds all power-over.
Your presence incites eternal wonder.
All praise to you, our comfort and our strength.
Amen and Amen!*

[enfleshed/adpt/lvf]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.

World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

We pause on this day,
as we join with others across our globe,
who, like us, yearn for peace;
who, like us, yearn for the day
when all people
live together in harmony and understanding.

We also pause to celebrate the joy of people coming together,
serving one another with common goals and concerns,
helping each other find our way,
sheltering those who need our help,
feeding those hungry for food and love,
and offering our very best for our children
and all the children of our world.
This is when we, our country and our world are at our very best.

We pause in these moments to give thanks to God for grace,
and ask for God's peace to be with us
in this time together, as we acknowledge
and honor the Divine in each of us with this greeting:

May the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke* **Shalonda Martin**

The Pharisees asked Jesus when the reign of God would come. Jesus replied, "The reign of God doesn't come in a visible way. You can't say, 'See, here it is!' or 'There it is!' No—look: the reign of God is already in your midst."

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of justice and mercy,
in these days we acknowledge that freedom is a constant struggle,
and the labor is hard,
but it is holy, too, and there is joy to be found in the laboring together.
Your healing salve of grace spills over, overflows,

and cannot be controlled or contained.
Your Gospel is indeed Good News
and your story brings the powerful down from their thrones
and lifts up the lowly.
Help us to remember your story is our story,
and the story is still being written
as we work together.

So, today, we pray:
Convict us with curiosity.
Convert us from complacency.
Consecrate us with compassion.
Conspire with us, as we lean into the New Life
emerging from the destruction around us.

Show us now, and in the days to come,
what we need to lay down
set aside
offer up
and divest from
in order for us all to be free.

Then, O God, help us to return to what matters most:
Seeking justice
practicing kindness
deepening into solidarity
with each other
with you
with the entangled, interconnected web of holy life
in which we live
and move
and have our being.
[adapt/enfleshed]

May we make it so?
May we make it so!
Amen and amen!

Meditation Anthem

"Hallelujah"
Cathedral Choir

KARISHA LONGACKER & SARAH NUTTING,
arr. DAVID HARRIS

Sermon

Kin-dom Vision

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Generosity

Shalonda Martin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"One People, One Family"
Cathedral Choir

DAVID GARCÍA SALDAÑA

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Shalonda Martin

God of the upside-down kin-dom,
how easily we swap your priorities for empire's promises.
We are prone to power-over, which leads us to control others,
rather than embrace power-with, which leads us to love that liberates others.

Thank you for consistently showing us a better way.
Help us seek first your kin-dom, not as a means to our own ends,
but as the end itself.

When empire's logic feels more practical than your priorities,
give us courage to trust your provision.
Through these, and all our gifts,
make us living witnesses to your transforming power,
not through domination but through love.

In the name of the Christ, Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

We dedicate our lives, God of Love.
Send us to work with you, where your love needs to be known.

*We open our hearts, Spirit of Life.
Show us where life needs to be recreated and shared.*

We offer to you, God of the Way,
our feet and hands.
Lead us to new paths, mature hope,
full of dreams and visions,
that we may enjoy the company
and the encounter with others.

*We pray, God of Love and Life,
sustain us with your hope,
renew us with your strength,
encourage us with your presence,*

*and embrace us with your grace,
today and every day, forever.*

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Ye Shall Have a Song" from The Peaceable Kingdom
Cathedral Choir

RANDALL THOMPSON

***Hymn for the Journey**

This is My Song

FINLANDIA

This is my song, O God of all the nations,
A song of peace for lands afar and mine.
This is my home, the country where my heart is,
Here are my hopes, my dreams, my holy shrine.
But other hearts in other lands are beating,
With hopes and dreams as true and high as mine.

My country's skies are bluer than the ocean,
And sunlight beams on clover leaf and pine.
But other lands have sunlight too, and clover,
And skies are everywhere as blue as mine.
O hear my song, O God of all the nations,
A song of peace for their land and for mine.

This is my song, O God of all the nations,
A song of peace for lands afar and mine.
This is my home, the country where my heart is,
Here are my hopes, my dreams, my holy shrine.
O hear my song, O God of all the nations,
A song of peace for their land and for mine.

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Little Great Prelude (Saginaw Rozzo) – Reprise

Inside The Music

"This was a hard week for me to plan music, as I'm feeling complicated by the national conversations this week. I assumed everyone else in our community is too at some level, and wasn't sure which way to go with music. When Esme shared her new piece with me today, it felt like a sign. The poem she set, by 17th century poet John Bunyan, was an answer of sorts to the questions circulating in my head. In short, life happens in the struggle. Whatever the question, we are here in this time, and this is the life we have been given. Esme's setting functions like a brain cipher. The opening lines repeat and layer, inspiring our confidence before yielding to more extended polyphony. Though we're only singing an excerpt, the rest of the piece behaves similarly, reaching out with greater and greater intensity as it calls upon us to open into newness. Esme has heard the piece sung once a few weeks ago, and we are pleased to be a part of its premiere moment. The "Hallelujah" we'll sing today is a favorite of mine. The choir sang it to Laurel and I at our wedding, and we've sung it to close our rehearsals every week for the last year. It reminds us, similarly, that amidst the struggle we find the deep wells that continue to feed us. We premiered David Saldaña's "One People, One Family" during quarantine and have continued to sing it annually. It's a tender and poignant reminder of the words both John Lewis and Dr. King were fond of sharing about the destiny we share with every one of our neighbors. We close with the final song from

Randall Thompson's "The Peaceable Kingdom" (my text edit). I love the promise from Isaiah that "ye shall have a song, and gladness of heart." Beyond that, life may go any number of directions, but wherever it goes, we still have that song, and we still have gladness of heart waiting for us. Thompson spreads the choir out across eight parts and builds in antiphonal splendor toward a massive final chord on the words "to come into the mountain of our God." That mountain path flows from the song and the gladness we've been promised. Perhaps life is truly that simple. We have our song. We have joy. We're headed toward, and have access to, something bigger than ourselves. That condensed promise feels like a motivating image. Oftentimes folks in power try to make us think things are complicated to keep us unsettled and anxious. Isaiah must have witnessed that as well as he brought forth such a focused measure for times like these." ~ Dr. David Harris

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